

CHAPTER TWO

My Feelings Are Friends

A week later, Sofia's stomach hurt.

It hurt the way it sometimes did in the mornings, which was a hurt that did not have anything stuck in it — no bad food, no flu, nothing a doctor could find. Sofia's mom had taken her to the doctor in kindergarten because of this stomach, and the doctor had said, very kindly, I think Sofia's stomach is talking to her.

Sofia had not understood, at the time, what that meant.

She understood it a little more, today, sitting on the carpet in Room 12, with her stomach hurting before reading.

Ms. Calloway took Sammy out of the box.

"Friends," said Sammy, "today we are going to talk about feelings. All of them. Even the ones you do not like."

Sammy looked at the carpet. "Sometimes feelings show up and you think — I do not want this feeling. Please go away. But feelings do not work like that. Feelings are like little messengers. They come to tell you something. If you yell at them, they get louder. If you listen, they tell you what they came to say. And then — when you have listened — they leave." Sofia did not say anything, but her stomach felt a little bit better. Sammy put up a chart that had four pictures on it. A smiling face. A sad face. A face that looked scared. A face that looked mad. "These are four feelings," said Sammy. "There are more than four. But these are four good ones to start with."

Today I am going to tell you what each one is for. Because every feeling — every single one — has a job. A feeling is a friend. A feeling is information."

The kids in Room 12 leaned in a little. Even Maya. Even Jordan, who was trying to make Theo laugh and got distracted by Sammy in the middle of doing it.

"Happy," said Sammy, "is the feeling that says more of this, please. It is the feeling that points at the things that are good for you, so you remember to do them again."

"Sad," said Sammy, "is the feeling that says something I love is gone, or far away, or hurt. Sad is not a bad feeling. Sad is just a true feeling about a real thing. When you feel sad, you can ask: what am I missing right now?"

"Scared," said Sammy, "is the feeling that says be careful. Scared keeps you safe. Scared is your friend. The only time scared is not helping is when it is yelling about something that is not really there. Then you can say: thank you, scared, I see what you mean, and I am okay." "Mad," said Sammy, "is the feeling that says something is not fair, or something is hurting me, or something needs to change. Mad is also your friend. Mad is information. Mad is how you know something matters to you."

Then Sammy stopped. The class was quiet.

"Friends," said Sammy, "the feeling is never the problem. The feeling is the messenger. If a feeling shows up — let it tell you what it came to say."

Sofia sat very still on the carpet.

After Sammy went back in the box, Ms. Calloway gave them all a piece of paper and asked them to draw a picture of a feeling they had that morning. Sofia thought for a long time. Then she drew a picture of her own stomach — a small round

circle in the middle of a small round body — and inside the stomach she drew a tiny worried face.

She brought the paper to Ms. Calloway during quiet work time. Ms. Calloway looked at the picture for a long moment.

"That is a wonderful picture, Sofia," she said. "What is your worried friend telling you?"

Sofia thought.

"I think," she said slowly, "my worried friend does not want me to mess up reading."

"That is good information," said Ms. Calloway. "Now you know what your worried friend is worried about. Can you tell your worried friend that messing up reading is okay in first grade? Messing up reading is how you learn reading."

Sofia nodded.

She went back to her seat, and during reading time, when she missed a word and the class did not laugh because the class never laughed when somebody missed a word in Ms. Calloway's class, Sofia put her hand on her stomach, very quietly, and said, in her head, thank you, worried friend. I heard you. We are okay.

Her stomach got a little softer.

This is one of the first things to learn about feelings. They are not your enemies. They are your friends. They have come a long way to tell you something. If you sit still, and listen, they will tell you what they came to say. Then they will go. And the next time they come, they will be a little quieter, because they know you will listen.